

KYOUNGMIN CHO

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ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Visiting Assistant Professor, Mount Holyoke College 2024 – Present

EDUCATION

University of Illinois Chicago (UIC), Ph.D. in Philosophy 2016 – 2024
Dissertation: *Ends in Activities*
Committee: Anthony Laden & Will Small (co-chairs), Marya Schechtman, Justin Vlasits, Anton Ford (UChicago)
University of Wisconsin at Milwaukee (UWM), M.A. in Philosophy 2013 – 2015
Teachers College, Columbia University, Ph.D. Student in Education 2012 – 2013
Korea University, M.A. in Education 2009 – 2011
Korea University, B.A. in Education & Sociology 2002 – 2009

RESEARCH & TEACHING AREAS

Areas of Specialization

Philosophy of Action, Ethics, Moral Psychology

Areas of Competence

Medical Ethics, Personal Identity, Metaphysics, Aristotle, Kant

PAPERS

“The Problem of the Infinite Regress of Ends” (R&R at *Ratio*)
“On Aristotle’s Test for *Energeia*” (R&R at *The Review of Metaphysics*)
“Against Subjectivism about Ultimate Ends: The Argument from Fickleness” (under review)
“Ends in Action: Production, Activity, and Actions Pursued for Their Own Sake” (in preparation)
“Actions, Processes, and Activities” (in progress)
“Against Mooreanism about Intrinsic Value” (in progress)

TALKS

† Refereed

On Actions as Ends in Themselves

Eastern APA Meeting Submitted Colloquium† Jan 2026
Neuchâtel Action Conference: Thin & Thick† Dec 2023

Against Subjectivism about Ultimate Ends: The Argument from Fickleness

Northwestern Society for the Theory of Ethics and Politics (NUSTEP)† Jun 2023
Texas Tech Graduate Philosophy Conference† Apr 2023
Central APA Annual Meeting Submitted Symposium† Feb 2023

<i>The Problem of the Infinite Regress of Ends</i>	
Eastern APA Meeting Submitted Colloquium†	Jan 2023
St. Louis Annual Conference on Reason & Rationality (SLACRR)†	May 2022
<i>On Aristotle's Test for Energeia</i>	
26th Annual Oxford Graduate Philosophy Conference†	Nov 2022
Eastern APA Annual Meeting Submitted Colloquium†	Jan 2022
21st Annual Columbia-NYU Graduate Conference in Philosophy†	Mar 2021
Central APA Annual Meeting Submitted Symposium†	Feb 2020
<i>Who is a Child?</i>	
American Educational Research Association (AERA) Annual Meeting†	Apr 2019

COMMENTS

“The Way Reasons Transmit to Necessary and Non-Necessary Means” by Seungcheul Yang	Feb 2025
Central APA Meeting Submitted Colloquium	
“The Order of Intentional Action” by Micha Glässer	Mar 2023
Northwestern Practical Philosophy Workshop	
“Between the Kingdom of Ends and the Doctrine of Right” by Khalilah Walters	Feb 2022
Central APA Meeting Submitted Symposium	
“Explaining What We Omit” by Grant, Rozeboom	Feb 2020
Central APA Meeting Submitted Symposium	

EARLIER PUBLICATIONS & BOOK REVIEW (IN KOREAN)

“교육철학자로서의 플라톤 (Review of Eric A. Havelock, Preface to Plato)”	2012
in 시대와 철학(<i>Epoch and Philosophy</i>) 109, pp. 147-175	
“듀이의 로티 해석의 정당성과 유용성 (The Validity of Rorty's Interpretation of Dewey)”	2011
in 철학(<i>Philosophy</i>) 109, pp. 147-175	
“듀이의 다윈주의 수용과 의의(Dewey's Acceptance of Darwinism and Its Significance)”	2011
in 사회와 철학(<i>Society and Philosophy</i>) 22, pp. 247-278	

AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

UIC Dean's Scholar Fellowship (\$30,000 plus tuition waiver)	2023 – 2024
Ruth Barcan Marcus Award (Outstanding Philosophy Graduate Student)	2023
UIC Award for Graduate Research (\$1998)	2022 – 2024
Korean American Scholarship Foundation Chair Scholarship (\$2,000)	2022
McPherson Fellow at the Center for Ethics and Education, (\$10,000)	2018 – 2019
Fulbright Graduate Study Award (\$70,000)	2012 – 2014

COURSES TAUGHT

At Mount Holyoke College

Self-Knowledge	Fall 2025
History of Modern Philosophy	Spring 2025, Fall 2025
Ethics	Spring 2025, Spring 2026
Action and Intention	Spring 2025, Fall 2026
Medical Ethics	Fall 2024, Fall 2025, Fall 2026
Personal Identity	Fall 2024, Spring 2026

Primary Instructor at UIC

What is a Person? Introduction to Philosophy	Spring 2019, Fall 2019
Introduction to Metaphysics	Spring 2021
Medical Ethics	Spring 2020
Introductory Logic	Summer 2019, Fall 2020, Summer 2021, Spring 2022, Summer 2022

Teaching Assistant at UIC

Introduction to Philosophy of Science	Spring 2021
Death	Spring 2020

DEPARTMENT SERVICE

At UIC

Organizer, Work in Progress Series	2017 – 2019
Colloquium Committee Representative	2016 – 2017

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Organizer, 2020 Chicagoland Graduate Philosophy Conference (canceled due to the pandemic)
Manuscript reviewer for *The Journal of Aesthetics and Art Criticism*, *Southwest Philosophy Review*

SELECTED GRADUATE COURSEWORK

† Audited

Practical Reasoning (Will Small, UIC)
Aristotle on Practical Wisdom (Michael Thompson, Pittsburgh)†
Kant's Critique of Pure Reason (Sally Sedgwick, UIC)
Actions, Events, and Processes (Will Small, UIC)†
Self, Time, and Narrative (Luca Ferrero, UWM)
Intentionality in Mind and Action (Matthew Boyle & Anton Ford, UChicago)†
Political Philosophy of John Rawls (Julius Sensat, UWM)
Agency and Normativity (Luca Ferrero, UWM)

REFERENCES

Research

Anthony Laden (laden@uic.edu)

Professor of Philosophy
University of Illinois Chicago

Will Small (wsmall@uic.edu)

Associate Professor of Philosophy
University of Illinois Chicago

Matthew Boyle (mbboyle@uchicago.edu)

Emerson and Grace Wineland Pugh Professor of Humanities
The University of Chicago

Anton Ford (antonford@uchicago.edu)

Associate Professor of Philosophy
The University of Chicago

Teaching

Justin Vlasits (jvlasits@uic.edu)

Associate Professor of Philosophy
University of Illinois Chicago

Katia Vavova (evavova@mtholyoke.edu)

Professor of Philosophy
Mount Holyoke College

Nina Emery (emery@mtholyoke.edu)

Professor of Philosophy
Mount Holyoke College

DISSERTATION ABSTRACT

Ends in Activities

My dissertation is about the ultimate source of justification for human action: it seeks to understand how the particular choices we make, and actions we perform thereby, are ultimately justified. It addresses this issue by focusing on a venerable philosophical problem—the problem of the infinite regress of ends. In my dissertation, I argue that this problem of regress can only be solved if we employ a neglected idea from Aristotle—namely, of action viewed as the activity (*energeia*) of a human agent. I maintain that since activity in the Aristotelian sense is an end in itself and is therefore justified by itself, it is the ultimate source of justification for human action.

Why do we need the ultimate source of justification for our action to begin with? Philosophers often answer that it's because otherwise, there would be the infinite regress of ends (e.g. Aristotle, Aquinas, Hume, Ross, and Korsgaard). But they seldom discuss how exactly the regress arises and why it is problematic. In Chapter 1, I thus articulate the problem of the infinite regress of ends. In paradigmatic cases, an intentional action is the action that an agent performs based on her reason. And the action is rational in the minimal sense that the agent can explain and justify her action by appealing to some *end* as her reason. But for an end as a reason to justify an action, the end itself must also be justified to be *reasonable* by some reason, which is none other than an end in action justification (No Unjustified Ends). Moreover, this justifying end cannot be identical with the end it justifies, since there must be either temporal or mereological distance between the two (No Circular Ends). Hence, if an end justifies an intentional action, that end must be justified by *another* end. By the same logic, this further end must also be justified by yet another end, generating an infinite regress. However, I argue that the justification of a justified end *is transmitted from* the justification of a justifying end. Thus if there is the infinite regress of ends in an agent's action justification, no end would ultimately be justified—and consequently, no action would be intentional. Since this is an absurd consequence, there must be no infinite regress of ends (No Infinite Regress of Ends). Given that these three compelling principles are inconsistent with each other, we now face a trilemma that I call the *Problem of the Regress*.

A common way of solving the Problem of the Regress is to reject No Unjustified Ends and claim that there are *ultimate* ends that need no justification—ends that are simply given. In Chapter 2, I argue against the most widespread adaptation of such a strategy, a view that I call *Subjectivism about Ultimate Ends*. According to Subjectivists (e.g. Hume, Russell, and Schroeder), ultimate ends are provided by subjective attitudes, especially by desires. But this view fails, I argue, because it can't explain the temporal structure of action that has certain normative implications. In most cases that matter to us, an intentional action takes time to be complete. If an action doesn't persist until it is complete, the action is incomplete and, in this regard, defective. So in a sense, the action *ought* to persist, and an agent has a normative reason to continue her action until she achieves its end. Furthermore, since an intentional action is based on an end as a reason that justifies it, an agent ought to sustain the end that justifies what she is doing as she ought to continue doing it, whether the end at issue is ultimate or not. Now, desires that are claimed to set the *ultimate* ends must be what Thomas Nagel calls *unmotivated desires* that are not derived from reasoning, precisely because those ends are supposed to require no justification. Thus an agent can't hold unmotivated desires for reasons. As ought implies can, it follows that it's not the case that an agent ought to hold unmotivated desires; an agent can't have normative reasons for holding them. Given that an agent's

having an end, including an ultimate one, needs to be sustained by an agent's reason, and that an agent's having an unmotivated desire cannot, we can conclude that an agent's having an ultimate end is not her having an unmotivated desire for it.

In Chapter 3, I argue against another strategy to solve the Problem of the Regress by rejecting No Unjustified Ends, a view that I call *Objectivism about Ultimate Ends*. Some philosophers (e.g. Moore, Lemos, and Zimmerman) argue that the ultimate ends of human actions are to bring about the objects or states of affairs that are intrinsically valuable. According to them, these objects are intrinsically valuable in that they are good solely in virtue of their intrinsic properties (the Supervenience Principle), and they are good of necessity (the Necessity Principle). To preserve the Supervenience Principle in the face of objections, Objectivists maintain that the bearers of intrinsic value are *actualized states of affairs* at a given time. However, the value of an actualized state of affairs cannot be necessarily good, since it is *defeasible*—that is, it could turn out to be bad if it causes a bad state of affairs in the future. This shows that the value of an ultimate end cannot be intrinsically good in a way that satisfies both the Supervenience Principle and the Necessity Principle.

Existing attempts to solve the Problem of the Regress thus fail. In Chapter 4, I present my own solution to the Problem. I argue that some actions are justified by themselves as they are ends for themselves—actions I call *autotelic actions*. Although it seems clear that we sometimes perform autotelic actions, the idea of autotelic action gives rise to conceptual difficulties. If an action is autotelic, it must be that in every moment in which the action is being performed, the action is complete and its end is achieved. But then it is logically impossible for the autotelic action to be incomplete and unsuccessful. This, however, doesn't seem true: it seems that every action, including autotelic ones, must be susceptible to failure. Let's call this difficulty the *Problem of Failure*. Furthermore, supposing that an end is the source of value for its action, if an action is autotelic, it must be that no matter when it is performed, the action is always good for an agent as the action is good for itself. But this doesn't seem true: sometimes performing an autotelic action is bad for an agent if the action is not conducive but rather detrimental to the quality of her life as a whole. Call this difficulty the *Problem of Valuation*. To solve these difficulties, we need to view an autotelic action not only as a production that brings about a certain state of affairs but also as an activity that actualizes an agent's nature. Insofar as an autotelic action is viewed as a production, it takes time to bring about the purported state of affairs, so it is possible that the action is interrupted in the meantime and so unsuccessful. But insofar as it is viewed as an activity, in every moment in which the action is being performed, an agent is actively being who she is: thus when it comes to realizing what she is supposed to be in acting, she can't fail to do so. Moreover, an autotelic action *qua* production can't be intrinsically good as its goodness depends on the current stage of an agent's life. But an autotelic action *qua* the activity of a rational human being is intrinsically good because in doing so, an agent is manifesting her practical identity as a unified whole and, in turn, actualizing who she is as an essentially rational animal that is required to have a unified self.

With this idea of activity as actualizing one's nature as a human being, we can solve the Problem of the Regress. We can reject No Circular Ends, No Unjustified Ends, and No Infinite Regress of Ends because, in the case of autotelic actions, (1) we have no reason to conclude that the actions and their ends are distinct, since there is no temporal distance between them when the actions are considered as activities; (2) autotelic actions are self-justifying and require no further justification, as they are ends in themselves; and (3) autotelic actions as activities can be manifested infinitely many times through various forms of production.